

Truth Nobody Can Hand You: Kierkegaard, the Crowd, and Indirect Communication

An original lesson plan inspired by **William McDonald's** the Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Søren Kierkegaard. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy or William McDonald. Explore the original course: <https://iep.utm.edu/kierkega/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

60 minutes

TOPICS

Existentialism

“Kierkegaard refused to publish most of his major works under his own name, writing instead through invented pseudonymous authors who often disagreed with each other — why would a philosopher deliberately make his own ideas harder to pin down, and can truth about how to exist really not just be handed to someone as a set of facts?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Kierkegaard's method of indirect communication and pseudonymous authorship, and his reasons for thinking direct philosophical argument is inadequate for communicating existential truths.
- Reconstruct Kierkegaard's definition of the self, from *The Sickness Unto Death*, as a relation that relates itself to itself, and his account of despair as a misrelation within that structure.
- Analyze Kierkegaard's critique of 'the crowd' and evaluate his claim that truth, in existential matters, is subjectivity — something that must be individually appropriated rather than merely publicly agreed upon.

Materials Needed

- Excerpt handout: the opening definition of the self from *The Sickness Unto Death*, and a short passage on 'the crowd' or 'the public'
- Pseudonym reference sheet listing several of Kierkegaard's pseudonyms (e.g., Johannes Climacus, Anti-Climacus, Judge William) and which perspective each represents
- Whiteboard for the hook activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Why Hide Behind a Fake Name?

8 min

Ask students to brainstorm reasons a real author might publish a book under a pseudonym rather than their own name. Collect answers on the board (privacy, trying out a different genre, protecting a reputation). Reveal that Kierkegaard published most of his philosophical works under invented authors who sometimes explicitly contradicted his other pseudonyms, and ask students to guess why a philosopher, of all people, would do this.

Direct Instruction: Indirect Communication

15 min

Introduce Kierkegaard's method of indirect communication: rather than handing readers a conclusion to accept on his authority, Kierkegaard uses pseudonymous voices representing different ways of existing (aesthetic, ethical, religious) so that readers must work out for themselves which perspective, if any, they actually hold. Explain his view that some truths — particularly truths about how to exist, not just what to believe — cannot be transferred like information; they must be personally worked through and appropriated, or they aren't really held at all.

Text Analysis: The Self as a Relation

18 min

In small groups, students read the opening definition of the self from *The Sickness Unto Death* excerpt: the self as a relation that relates itself to its own relating (for instance, between the finite and infinite, the temporal and eternal, freedom and necessity). Groups work to paraphrase this famously dense definition in plain language, then apply it to define despair as what happens when the self fails to relate to itself properly — whether by refusing to be the self it actually is, or refusing to become the self it is capable of becoming.

Discussion: The Crowd vs. the Single Individual

14 min

Introduce Kierkegaard's critique of 'the crowd' or 'the public': a collective can diffuse responsibility so completely that no single person feels answerable for anything, letting individuals hide from the demanding work of becoming a genuine self. Discuss his claim that truth, in this existential sense, is 'subjectivity' — not that all opinions are equally valid, but that a truth only counts as truly held if it is inwardly appropriated by a single individual, not merely repeated because 'everyone says so.'

Closure

5 min

Ask students to identify one belief or value they hold mostly because 'everyone around them holds it' versus one they have genuinely, individually worked through. Collect a few examples to close the discussion.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If Kierkegaard is right that some truths can't simply be handed to you but must be personally appropriated, does that mean philosophy classes and textbooks are actually the wrong format for teaching those truths?
- 2 Is Kierkegaard's self-relation definition ('a relation that relates itself to itself') a genuine insight into what a person is, or is it needlessly obscure language for something simpler?
- 3 Does hiding behind pseudonyms who disagree with each other actually help a reader think for themselves, or does it let Kierkegaard avoid ever being pinned down to a position he has to defend?

- 4 Kierkegaard worries that 'the crowd' lets individuals avoid responsibility — can you think of a modern example (online or otherwise) where being part of a large group seems to dissolve anyone's individual sense of accountability?
- 5 If truth in existential matters is 'subjectivity,' how would Kierkegaard respond to the worry that this makes truth arbitrary, since anyone could sincerely 'appropriate' a belief that is objectively false or harmful?

Assessment

Students write a short response paraphrasing Kierkegaard's definition of the self as a relation in their own words, then applying it to explain, in a concrete example, what despair (a misrelation within the self) might look like for a specific kind of person — someone in denial about who they are, or someone refusing to grow into who they could become.

Extension Activity

Have students find a real-world example of an author, artist, or public figure who used a pseudonym or alter ego for reasons other than simple concealment, and write a short comparison of their reasons to Kierkegaard's stated reasons for indirect communication.

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